

AUTONOMOUS PRODUCTION CHOKE CONTROLLER

Problem Statement ID - Honeywell Hackathon, Problem 3A

Problem Statement Title - Autonomous Production Choke Controller for a Single Naturally Flowing Oil Well

Theme - Industrial Process Control / Oil & Gas Automation

PS Category - Software

Student Name - Divyansh Gupta (VIT Vellore)

PROCESS UNDERSTANDING & MODEL

Step test: 120 hr open-loop, choke 30->40->55->45->65 %, Ts = 1 hr

Response is first-order (time constant ~5 hr on oil rate), mild noise

Opening choke RAISES oil rate but LOWERS WHP / FLP / BHP

=> the binding safety constraints are LOWER pressure bounds

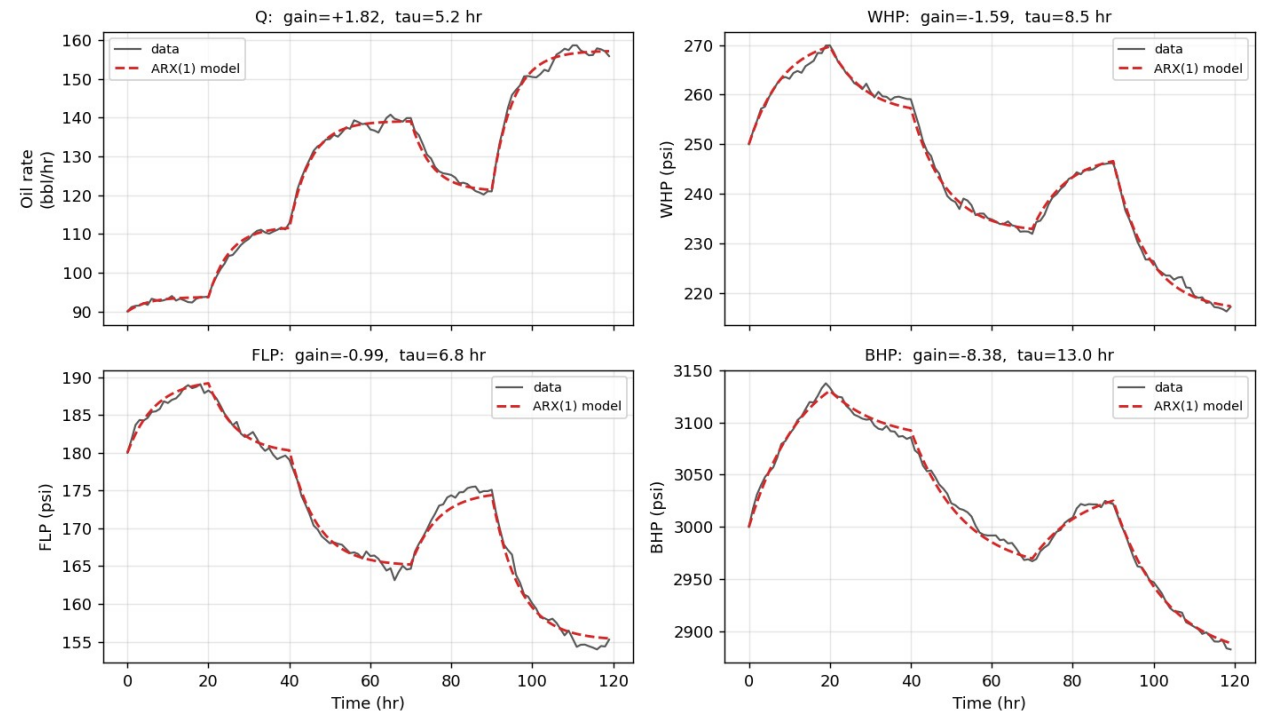
Model: ARX(1) per output by least squares

$y[k+1] = a.y[k] + (1-a)(b_0 + b_1.u[k])$; free-run fit 1.5-2.4 % of span

Identified steady-state gains (per % choke):

Q +1.82 bbl/hr WHP -1.59 FLP -0.99 BHP -8.38 psi

Model identification: ARX(1) free-run vs. step-test data



CONTROL STRATEGY

Simplified MPC by brute-force candidate search (per brief)

Each hour, enumerate choke +/- up to 5 % (ramp-feasible, fine grid)

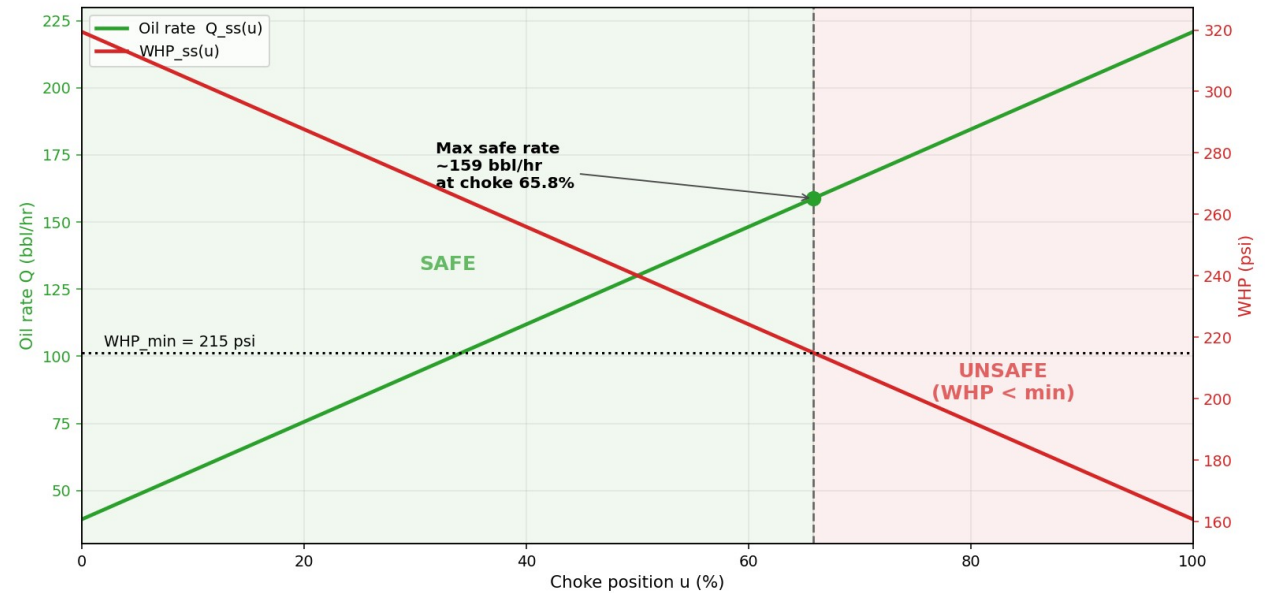
Predict each candidate's pressures over a settling horizon + steady state

REJECT any move predicted to breach WHP/FLP/BHP + safety margin

Among safe moves, minimise $(Q_{ss} - \text{target})^2 + \lambda \cdot (\Delta \text{choke})^2$

Infeasible target => same cost settles at the highest safe rate

Monotonic first-order response: steady-state feasibility proves the whole trajectory safe -> safe-by-construction, 0 violations



RESULTS - TARGET TRACKING (A & B)

Scenario A - Startup -> 130 bbl/hr

settles 129.9 bbl/hr, steady-state error -0.11, 0 violations

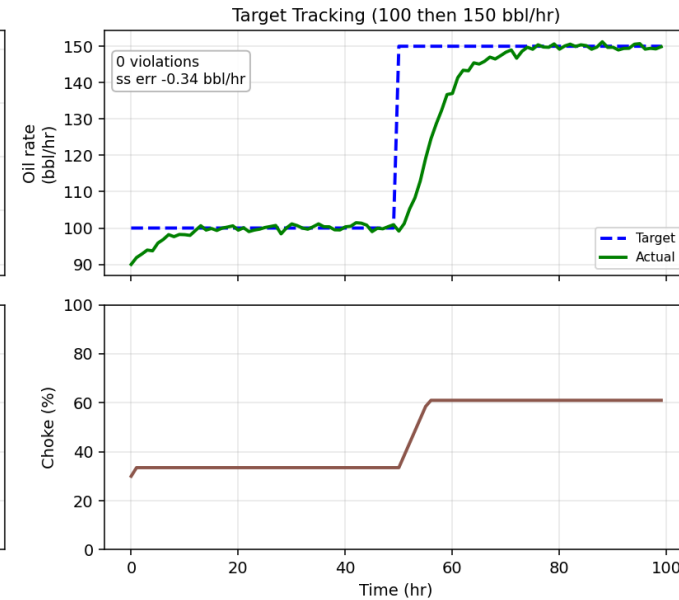
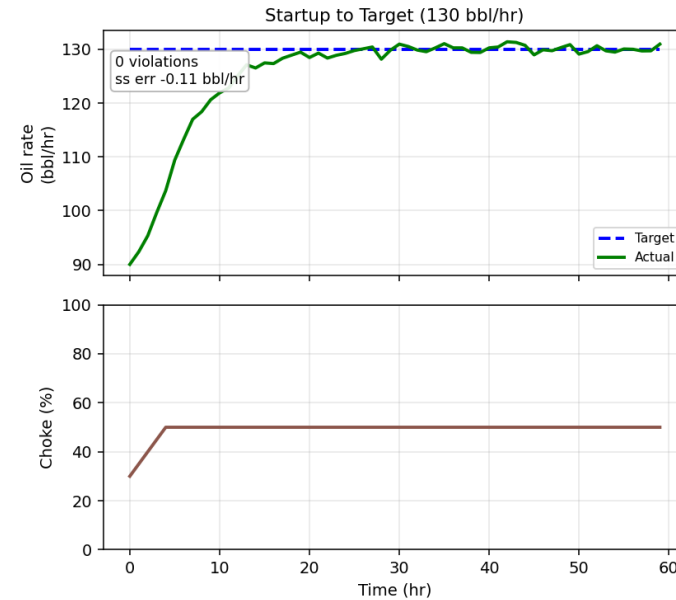
Scenario B - Target step 100 -> 150 bbl/hr

settles 149.7 bbl/hr, steady-state error -0.34, 0 violations

Pressures stay inside the envelope throughout

Choke moves are smooth and respect the +/-5 %/step ramp limit

Feasible-target tracking: Scenario A (startup) and Scenario B (100->150)



SAFETY PERFORMANCE & LESSONS LEARNED

Scenario C - infeasible 185 bbl/hr: controller REFUSES,
settles at max safe 154.9 bbl/hr with 0 violations

**Robust: 0 violations under +/-20% plant mismatch, unmeasured
disturbances and 2x noise (22-case stress study, robustness.py)**

Lessons learned:

Binding constraint is a lower pressure bound, not an upper rate cap

Monotonicity makes a cheap brute-force MPC provably safe

Model error costs production, never safety - margin is the dial

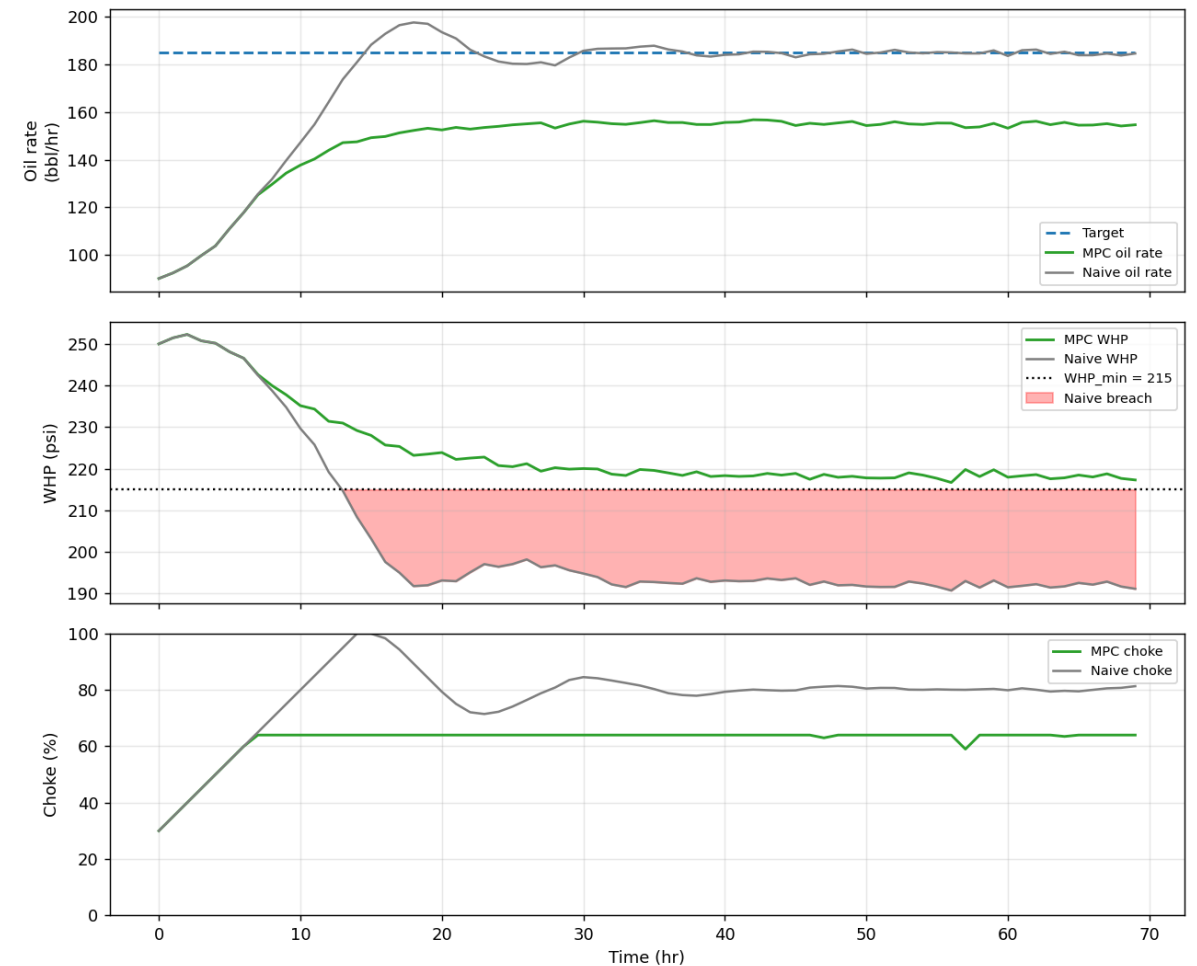
0

MPC violations (A/B/C)

168

naive-baseline breaches on C

Safety-first MPC vs. naive baseline -- Scenario C -- Infeasible Target (185 bbl/hr, settle at max safe)



ARTIFACTS & REFERENCES

Code (flat Python modules at repo root):

dataio, model_id, envelope, simulator, controller, plotting, scenarios, main

Executed Jupyter notebook + technical report.md + results/ (plots, metrics.json)

Live dashboard: [streamlit run app.py](#) (scenario presets, per-step

MPC diagnostics: candidates rejected as unsafe, WHP margin)

Robustness: [python robustness.py](#) (22 stress cases: noise, +/-20%

mismatch, unmeasured disturbances)

Run: [pip install -r requirements.txt](#) && [python main.py](#)

main.py asserts 0 envelope violations across A/B/C

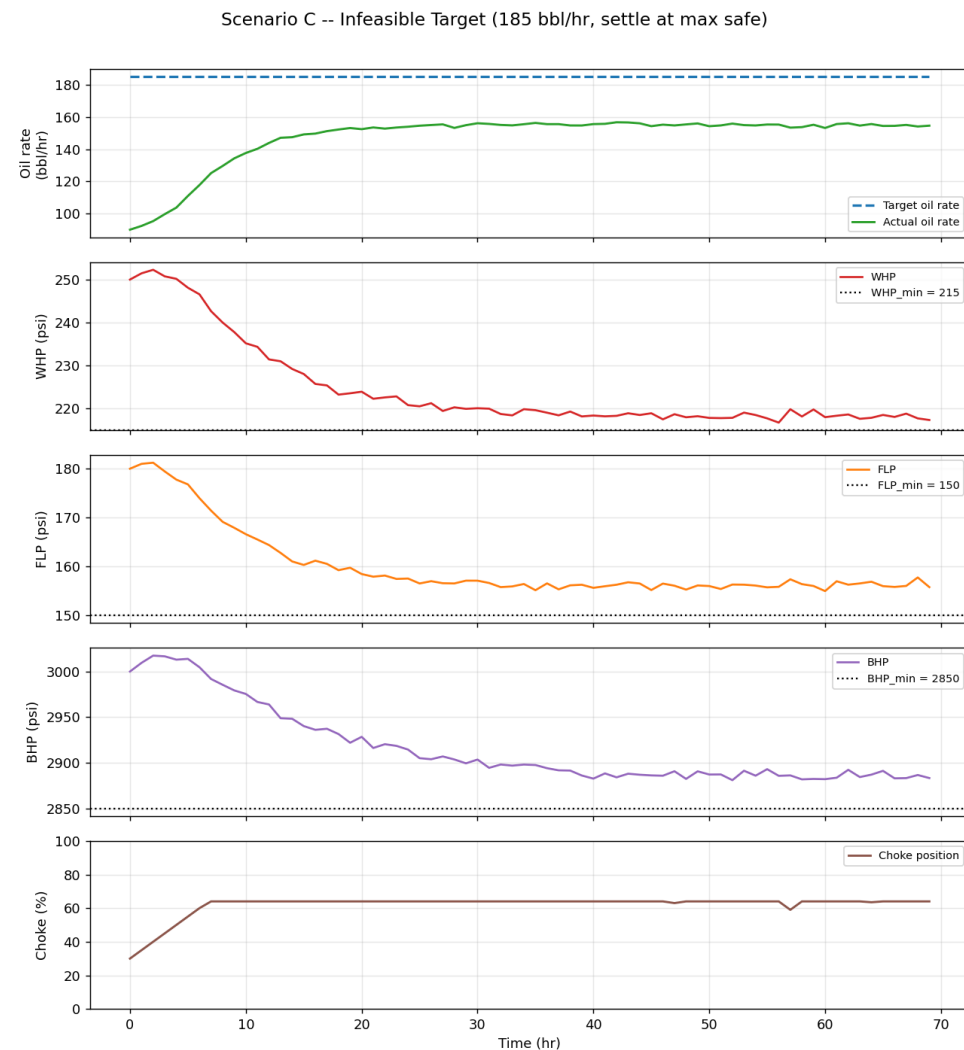
Simulator stand-in shares the official .step(choke)->(Q,WHP,FLP,BHP)

signature -> the real event simulator drops in with a one-line change

Repo: github.com/Divyansh2602/autonomous-choke-controller

References: least-squares system identification (Ljung); simplified

MPC by brute-force candidate evaluation (Honeywell brief)



Required 6-trend plot (Scenario C shown)